GUESS for Ecology

Food webs, trophic levels and omnivory, keystones and extinction cascades, compartments, mutualistic networks and nestedness, with an extinction explorer

Contents

1 Why networks? 1

2 Food webs 2
2.1 Build a food web and draw it by level Basic . . . 2
2.2 Who eats whom: roles and levels Basic . . . 4
2.3 What does a predator depend on? Basic . . . 4

3 Keystones and extinctions 4
3.1 Extinction cascades Intermediate . . . 4
3.2 Find the keystone species Intermediate . . . 5

4 Structure 6
4.1 Compartments Basic . . . 6

5 Mutualistic networks 6
5.1 Is a pollination network nested? Advanced . . . 6

6 Real data 7
6.1 Fetch observed interactions Intermediate . . . 7

7 Case study 7
7.1 Case study: top-down or bottom-up? Intermediate . . . 7

8 Capstone 8
8.1 Capstone: an extinction explorer Advanced . . . 8

Why networks?

An ecosystem is a network of who eats whom, who pollinates whom, who parasitises whom. The network view asks questions about the whole that no single species' biology answers:

- How long are the food chains, and who sits at the top?
- Which species does everything else depend on?
- If a species disappears, how many others follow it?
- Do communities split into compartments?

- Are mutualisms organised (nested), or random?

This book assumes the Kitchen. In its food webs, **edges run from food to eater**, the direction energy flows. A species' `indegree` is how many things it eats (its *generality*) and its `outdegree` how many things eat it (its *vulnerability*).

Most recipes use model food webs that GUESS generates, so the numbers are reproducible and need no data files. The niche model (first recipe) produces webs with the structure of real ones. The real-data recipe uses the Global Biotic Interactions database (GloBI), which needs an internet connection.

Food webs

Build a food web and draw it by level Basic

You want a food web to work with, drawn so that the producers are at the bottom and the top predators at the top.

Ingredients: `makeNicheModel` · `trophicLevels` · `scatterLayout`

```
makeNicheModel(40, 0.12, seed=1)
trophicLevels()
scatterLayout(niche, trophic)
colorize(role)
sizeBy(degree, 6, 24)
legendFor(role)
```

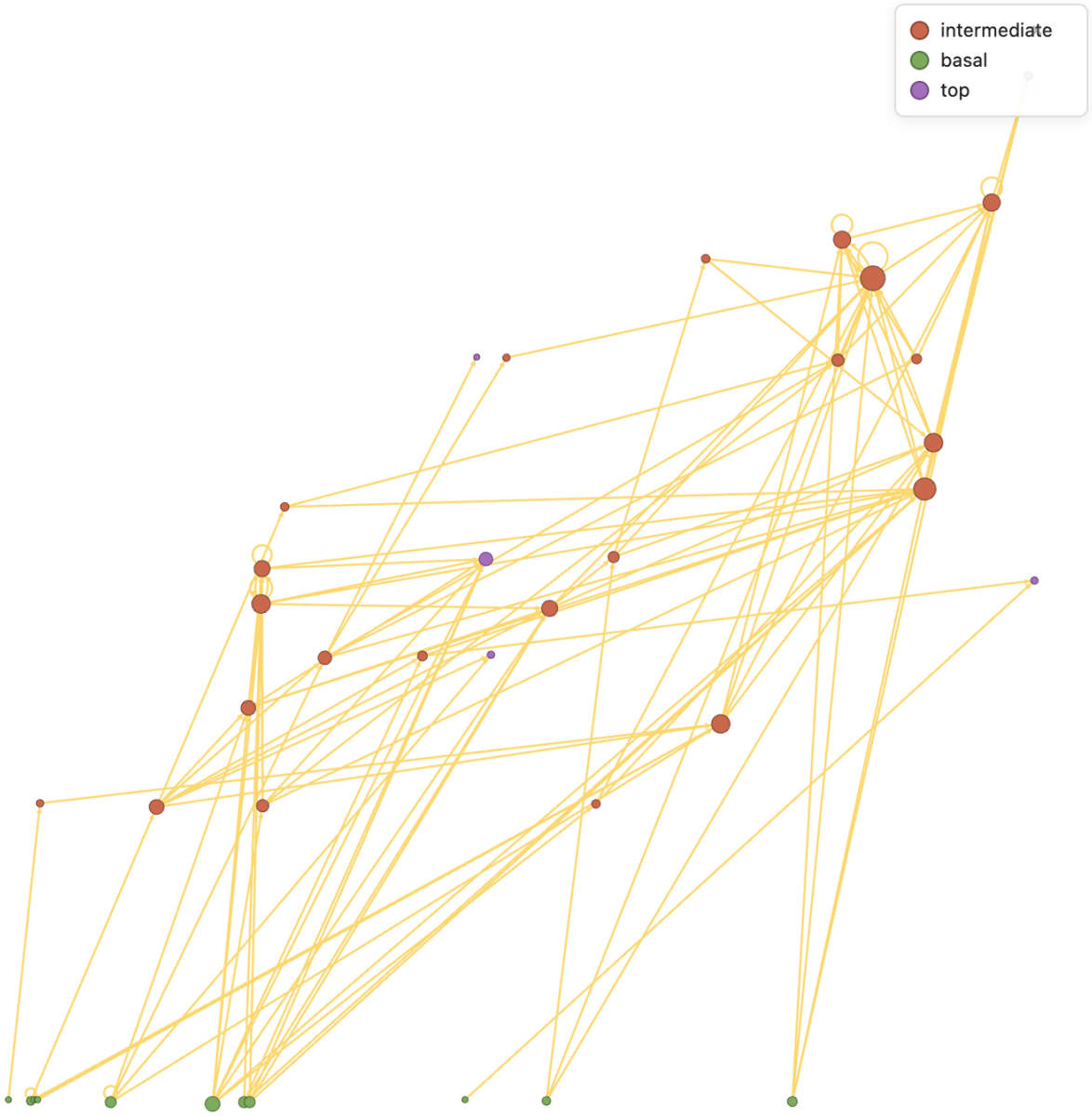


Figure 1: A niche-model food web, drawn by niche (across) and trophic level (up)

How it works. `makeNicheModel(species, connectance)` places each species on a niche axis from 0 to 1 and lets it eat every species whose niche falls within a range below its own: the *niche model* of Williams and Martinez (2000). It's simple, but its webs match many statistics of real ones. Connectance is links ÷ species², the share of possible feeding links that exist (0.05–0.3 in nature). The web you get varies around it: this one has 39 species and 111 links, connectance 0.073. `trophicLevels()` then computes each species' trophic level: 1 for species that eat nothing in the web, otherwise one more than the average level of what it eats. `scatterLayout(niche, trophic)` draws the classic food-web picture.

Who eats whom: roles and levels Basic

```
makeNicheModel(40, 0.12, seed=1)
trophicLevels()
[(grp[0].role, len(grp)) for grp in groupBy(role)]
for n in sortBy(trophic)[-3:]: print(n.name, round(n.trophic, 2), n.role,
 ↪  n.indegree, n.outdegree, round(n.omnivory, 2))
```

How it works. `role` classifies species as *basal* (eats nothing in the web: producers, or detritus), *top* (nothing in the web eats it) or *intermediate*. Here there are 12 basal, 22 intermediate and 5 top species, with trophic levels from 1 to 4.45 (mean 2.36). `omnivory` is the spread of the levels a species eats from. A strict herbivore has 0, and a species eating plants and carnivores alike has a high value. Omnivory is common in real webs, and it blurs the textbook picture of neat levels.

Pitfalls. Trophic levels depend on resolution. A web that lumps "phytoplankton" into one node and splits fish into twenty species will have long chains at the top and short ones at the bottom, whatever nature does. Compare webs only at similar resolution.

What does a predator depend on? Basic

```
makeNicheModel(40, 0.12, seed=1)
trophicLevels()
top = sortBy(trophic)[-1]
needs = ancestors(top)
needs.color = orange
top.color = red
len(needs), len(g.nodes)
```

How it works. Following edges backwards from a predator, `ancestors` gives everything upstream: its food, its food's food, down to the producers. The highest predator here depends, directly or indirectly, on 33 of the 39 species. `descendants(species)` goes the other way: every species that eats it, or eats something that does.

Keystones and extinctions

Extinction cascades Intermediate

You want to know how a web responds to species loss, and which losses hurt most.

Ingredients: a food web · `extinctions`

```
makeNicheModel(40, 0.12, seed=1)
r = extinctions(["random", "degree", "least", "basal"])
```

How it works. `extinctions()` removes species one by one (*primary* extinctions), and any species left with nothing to eat dies out too (*secondary* extinctions). Basal species never starve. It plots the share of species surviving as removals proceed, and prints **R50**, the share of primary removals that costs half the species. Higher is more robust. For this web:

removal order	R50
random	0.44
least connected first	0.44
most connected first (`"degree"`)	0.33
producers first (`"basal"`)	0.21

Losing the most connected species first does more harm than random loss, and losing producers first does the most. The most connected species here are intermediate predators, and many species depend on them through few routes. The graph isn't changed, so try any order, including a field of your own (`extinctions(threat)`).

Pitfalls. This is a topological model. Real secondary extinctions also happen through population dynamics: a predator released from control, a competitor freed. Those can make cascades worse than topology predicts (when a top predator goes) or better (when consumers switch prey).

Find the keystone species Intermediate

```
makeNicheModel(40, 0.12, seed=1)
addNodeField("cascade", INTEGER, 0)
import networkx as nx
G = toNetworkX()
for n in g.nodes:
    H = G.copy()
    H.remove_node(n.name)
    gone = 1
    changed = True
    while changed:
        changed = False
        for sp in list(H):
            if G.in_degree(sp) > 0 and H.in_degree(sp) == 0:
                H.remove_node(sp)
                gone += 1
                changed = True
    n.cascade = gone - 1
for n in sortBy(cascade)[-5:]: print(n.name, n.cascade, n.degree)
sizeBy(cascade, 6, 30)
```

How it works. A *keystone* is a species whose loss causes losses out of proportion to its abundance or links. This recipe removes each species in turn from a copy of the web (`toNetworkX()`), lets the starving consumers die out, and stores how many species followed it in `cascade`. Sizing by `cascade` shows the keystones at once. In this web no single loss is catastrophic: the worst, `s17`, takes three other species with it. The species that set off cascades are producers and low-level consumers (trophic levels 1 to 2.5) that some consumers depend on entirely. They are not the best-connected species, which have 11 to 16 links and set off no cascade at all.

Structure

Compartments Basic

```
makeNicheModel(40, 0.12, seed=1)
trophicLevels()
louvainClusters()
colorize(modularity_class)
scatterLayout(niche, trophic)
```

How it works. Food webs are often *compartmentalised*: groups of species that interact mostly among themselves, such as a soil web and a canopy web. Compartments slow the spread of disturbances. Here Louvain finds four compartments (modularity 0.44). In a niche-model web they are overlapping stretches of the niche axis (from 0–0.65 up to 0.5–0.94), because species eat near their own niche.

Mutualistic networks

Is a pollination network nested? Advanced

You have a plant–pollinator (or seed-disperser, or host–parasite) network. **You want** to know whether it's *nested*: specialists interacting with subsets of the generalists' partners.

Ingredients: a two-mode network · `nestedness` · `rewire(keep=…)`

```
import random
addNodeField("kind", VARCHAR, None)
rng = random.Random(4)
plants = [addNode(f"plant{i}") for i in range(15)]
bees = [addNode(f"bee{i}") for i in range(25)]
for p in plants: p.kind = "plant"
for b in bees: b.kind = "pollinator"
ap = [rng.paretovariate(1.2) for _ in plants]
ab = [rng.paretovariate(1.2) for _ in bees]
for i, p in enumerate(plants):
    for j, b in enumerate(bees):
        if rng.random() < min(1, 0.08 * ap[i] * ab[j]):
            addEdge(p, b)
removeDisconnected()
bipartiteLayout(kind)
nestedness(kind, rows="plant")
rewire(keep=kind)
nestedness(kind, rows="plant")
```

How it works. The first block builds a model pollination network: 15 plants and 25 bees with very uneven abundances (`paretovariate`), and each pair interacts with a probability proportional to their two abundances. `nestedness(kind)` computes NODF (Almeida-Neto et al., 2008), from 0 (no nesting) to 100 (perfect). Here it's 67.6. Is that high? It depends on the null model:

- **Against random links**, it's high. A two-mode network with the same number of links placed at random scores about 47.
- **Against the same degrees**, it isn't. `rewire(keep=kind)` shuffles links while keeping every species' number of partners and keeping plants linked only to pollinators, and scores 67.5, the same as the original.

The nestedness of this network is fully explained by its uneven abundances, which is how it was built. Whether real networks are more nested than their degrees imply is a live question in ecology, and the answer depends on exactly this choice.

Pitfalls. `rewire()` without `keep=` would happily link plants to plants, which a pollination network can't contain, and would score a misleading 36. Always constrain a null model to what's possible in the system.

Real data

Fetch observed interactions Intermediate

```
makeFromGloBI(["Vulpes vulpes", "Lynx lynx", "Canis lupus"], limit=300)
colorize(query)
sizeBy(degree, 4, 30)
forceAtlas2Layout()
```

How it works. `makeFromGloBI(taxa, interaction)` asks the Global Biotic Interactions database for recorded interactions of each taxon: `"eats"` (the default), `"preysOn"`, `"pollinates"`, `"parasiteOf"`, `"visitsFlowersOf"` and more. Feeding links run from food to eater, like the model webs. GloBI aggregates studies, museum records and observations. A single request for the red fox returns nearly 200 recorded foods, from squirrels and chipmunks to nightshade and elder berries. Querying several predators shows which prey they share: the start of a regional web.

Pitfalls. GloBI records what was observed and reported, which mixes studies of different places, seasons and methods. It's a literature database, not a food web of one place and time. Cite GloBI and its underlying sources (each record has one).

Case study

Case study: top-down or bottom-up? Intermediate

```
makeNicheModel(40, 0.12, seed=1)
trophicLevels()
top = sortBy(trophic)[-1]
ss("web")
remove(top)
recompute()
len(g.nodes)
ls("web")
r = extinctions(["basal"], show=False)
next(x for x, y in r["basal"] if y <= 0.5)
```

Removing the top predator costs exactly one species, itself: in a topological model nothing depends on a predator. Removing producers first, the web loses half its species after a fifth of the removals. Topologically, food webs are fragile from the bottom up. Field ecology shows top-down effects are real too: the loss of predators can transform an ecosystem through cascading changes in abundance, such as sea otters, urchins and kelp forests. That's the limit of a who-eats-whom network. It shows dependence, not dynamics. Pair it with population models when abundance matters.

Capstone

Capstone: an extinction explorer Advanced

The problem. A conservation planner wants to ask "what if?" of a food web: what happens if this species is lost, or that one, or those three? This recipe builds a small explorer:

- the web drawn by trophic level;
- click a species to remove it, and watch the consumers that starve turn grey;
- a running count of species lost, against those removed directly;
- a drop-down to apply a whole removal order at once, and a slider for how far to go;
- a reset button, and the cascade curves in a chart beside the web.

```
makeNicheModel(40, 0.12, seed=1)
trophicLevels()
scatterLayout(niche, trophic)
colorize(role)
legendFor(role)
addNodeField("lost", VARCHAR, None)
prey = {n: [e.node1 for e in n.getInEdges()] for n in g.nodes}
state = {"removed": []}

def cascade():
    gone = set(state["removed"])
    changed = True
    while changed:
        changed = False
        for n in g.nodes:
            if n not in gone and prey[n] and all(p in gone for p in prey[n]):
                gone.add(n)
                changed = True
    for n in g.nodes:
        n.lost = None if n not in gone else ("removed" if n in state["removed"]
↪   else "starved")
    (lost == "removed").color = black
    (lost == "starved").color = "200,200,200"
    report.text = f"removed {len(state['removed'])}, starved {len(gone) -
↪   len(state['removed'])}, surviving {len(g.nodes) - len(gone)} of
↪   {len(g.nodes)}"
    StatusBar.setStatus(report.text)

def remove_species(n):
```

```
    if n not in state["removed"]:
        state["removed"].append(n)
    cascade()

def reset():
    state["removed"] = []
    colorize(role)
    cascade()

def apply_order(name):
    key = {"most connected": lambda n: -n.degree, "least connected": lambda n:
 ↪  n.degree,
           "highest level": lambda n: -n.trophic, "producers": lambda n:
            ↪  n.trophic}[name]
    order = sorted(g.nodes, key=key)
    reset()
    state["removed"] = order[:int(depth.value)]
    cascade()

report = Label("click a species to remove it")
order = Dropdown(["most connected", "least connected", "highest level",
 ↪  "producers"], label="order",
                  onChange=apply_order)
depth = Slider(0, 20, 5, label="species removed", onChange=lambda v:
 ↪  apply_order(order.value))
ui.dock(Panel("Extinction explorer", order, depth, Button("Reset",
 ↪  onClick=reset), report, position="bottom"))
graphevents.clickNode = remove_species
_ = extinctions(["random", "degree", "basal"])
cascade()
center()
```

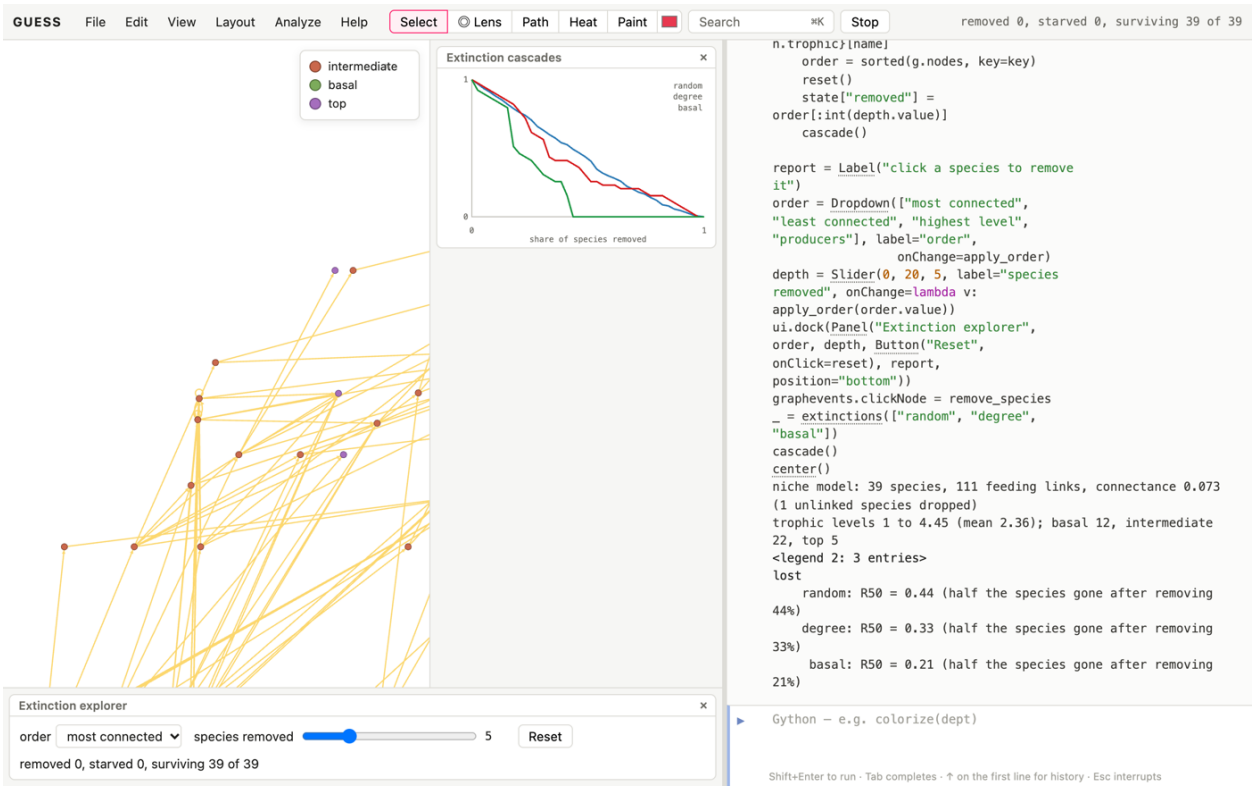


Figure 2: The extinction explorer: removed species black, starved species grey

How it works.

- **The cascade.** `prey` records what each species eats, once. `cascade()` repeats the extinction rule until nothing changes: a consumer whose food is all gone starves. It writes the outcome into the `lost` field and colours by it, which shows the result on the drawing.
- **Clicking.** `graphevents.clickNode = remove_species` turns every click on a species into a removal.
- **The controls.** `Dropdown` and `Slider` apply a whole removal order to a chosen depth. The `Label` and `StatusBar` keep the count in view.
- **The chart.** `extinctions()` draws the cascade curves of standard orders in the chart panel, for comparison.

Variations.

- Swap the model web for real data from `makeFromGloBI`, or for your own web from a file.
- Give species a `threat` field (an extinction-risk category) and add it to the drop-down's orders.
- `exportApp()` shares the explorer as a page.